



AGILE PASSPORT

Module 2 – Case Study & Task



Case Study – Millers Marmalade

History and Background

The Miller family are farmers, and three years ago they successfully expanded into a new area: making and selling of a wide range of marmalades (citrus fruit jams – typically orange jam). They have been so successful that Food World (FW), an international food company has recently taken a 20% share in Millers Marmalade. Although this has helped provide capital and advice on accessing international markets, the parent company has left Millers reasonably independent and in charge of running their own business.



Millers sell most of their marmalade to national supermarkets ('trade sales'). This is the core of their business and is handled by account managers who have built up good relationships with several large customers. They currently use informal systems such as spreadsheets and simple database applications but this is now inefficient and results in mistakes being made as the trade volumes are growing rapidly. They now want to expand the sales of marmalade more widely to the general public.

The general public can already buy marmalade from a very basic website that Millers run and maintain. However, supporting and enhancing the website is now causing problems for Millers.

Millers have converted several farm buildings to provide facilities to create large volumes of marmalade. Some of their processes are fully automated such as the making of the marmalade, temperature controlled storage and the cleaning and filling of the marmalade jars.

Millers employ 27 staff who run the machinery, customer service and distribution. They have recently outsourced most of their delivery functions to national transport contractors and to local delivery companies.

Last year Millers made a profit of €50,000 which pleased the directors as they had invested heavily in the marmalade side of the business since it launched three years ago.



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Award Winners

Recently Millers Marmalade won the special “Orange d’Or” award at an international marmalade festival in France and the publicity this created has led to a significant rise in orders and enquiries.

Everyone at Millers has been very excited about the award and the directors of Millers have decided that they can harness the staff enthusiasm to set another target with a deadline in 6 months time: to get Millers listed on the “100 Best Food Websites” which is a very popular national television (TV) programme.

Achieving this could double the demand for Millers Marmalade within months, (specifically Millers would aim to double sales within 2 months following the TV programme).



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Work to be done

If Millers go forward with the idea of being listed in the “100 Best Food Websites” the current work they have identified is:

- A significant upgrade to the existing website (or even a new website) in order to offer more advanced features to engage with their customers
- A complete rebranding of the Millers Marmalade image
- Creation of a larger office by moving from the current office: from their small farm building to one of the much larger ones.
- Recruitment of 6 more staff to help with the increased workload
- A marketing campaign to take advantage of the success of the recent
- Award

From initial research done it seems that Millers could rebrand for €20,000. The office move and refit would cost €35,000. A recruitment campaign including a local recruitment event would cost €18,000 (assuming a percentage fee to be paid for 6 staff, based on an average salary of €20,000 per annum). A local company would be engaged for the recruitment.

Costs for the website are €24,000 to build, plus a support contract of €400 per month. Initial estimates suggest that the profit from increased sales could pay for the cost of the website within a few months. It is critical that the efficiency of the existing website, processes and systems are not affected while any changes are made.

It has been decided that Agile Project Management is to be used for the project to produce the website.



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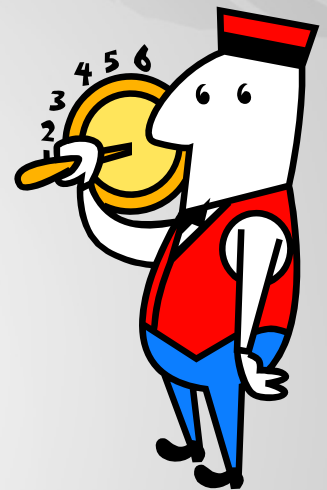


Elevator Pitch Exercise

Read the Case Study provided in the support materials for this module and then create a short project objective statement describing why the project detailed in the case study is taking place (to explain to the CEO of your company in a couple of minutes). Your pitch should include a short presentation on the major benefits and risks of running the upgrade to the existing website or new website development project in an agile way.

An Elevator Pitch is a short overview of the main points, delivered as if you have a key person for a few minutes in an elevator.

(Note: here we are not looking for the project risks/benefits which would be true for any approach. Consider here the risks of using Agile.)



Exercise objectives

1. *It is a good practice, at the outset of a project, to summarise, in a short, succinct way, what the project is about, to help to promote a unified vision of the objectives and direction of the project. This is particularly useful in Agile.*
2. *Using Agile often involves a PM “selling” the approach to be taken. This works best when supported by a balanced assessment of benefits and risks, rather than just enthusiasm (although enthusiasm is good!).*

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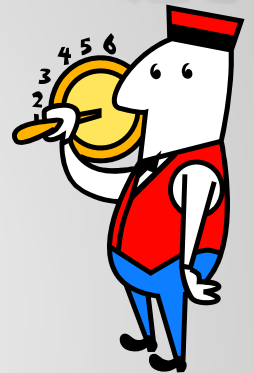
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Elevator Pitch Exercise Prepared Answer

It is not expected that your answer should be the same but it should be picking up on these key points.

Due to our success in expanding into marmalade production and the push to expand the sales of marmalade more widely to the general public we are finding that our informal back office systems are now inefficient and we are making mistakes as trade volumes grow. Our very basic web site is no longer fit for purpose and we are finding that the need to update and enhance more frequently is causing us problems. We are keen to maximise on the “Orange d’Or” award, which has already led to a significant rise in orders and enquiries, by putting ourselves forward for listing on the “100 Best Food Websites”.



We have set ourselves a target of 6 months for this and the requirement to produce an enhanced website to meet this constrained timeframe is an ideal situation to apply an Agile style of project management. We understand that there will be changes that will need to be incorporated and for that reason we don’t want to spend too much time developing up front. We understand that the budget is constrained and there will be a need to prioritize in order to ensure we meet the requirements both for our business and the “100 best food site” criteria.

Using an iterative approach to delivering will mean that we can address the main business priorities first and then revisit the website to look at future enhancements. The advantage for Miller’s is that an Agile approach will deliver within budget, on time and to a level of quality required but there has been an understanding that the features will need to be prioritized to accomplish this. Miller’s needs to be fully supportive of this approach in order for the benefits to be fully realized.

The Agile approach is highly collaborative and there will need to be frequent liaison with the business in order to deliver a website that will meet the needs of our customers. This level of business involvement is crucial to the success of the project and Miller’s needs to be fully supportive of this in order for the project to be successful.

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